

Apply to be a Science Corps Fellow - Entry #3405

Name
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Female
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Los Angeles
Nationality
American
When did you or do you expect to complete your PhD?
June 2027
Please tell us briefly about your university education (institution, city, country, year)
I earned my B.S. in Evolution, Ecology, and Biodiversity with honors in 2021 from the University of California, Davis in Davis, California, USA. I received a Departmental Citation in Evolution, Ecology, and Biodiversity from the UC Davis Department of Evolution and Ecology and a Distinguished Scholar Award from the UC Davis College of Biological Sciences. I am currently a PhD Candidate in the Department of Ecology and Evolutionary Biology at the University of California, Los Angeles in Los Angeles, California, USA. I am expected to complete my PhD by June of 2027.
Why would you like to be a Science Corps Fellow?
“Punta tayo sa palengke ‘nak,” my mom asked – “Let’s go to the wet market” in Tagalog, my native tongue. We jumped in the nearest motor tricycle on the small village road to the to the village wet market, where vendors sell everything from home-sewn clothes to freshly harvested produce and seafood from the morning’s catch. My family were subsistence fishers or worked for fishpond owners raising their stocks to get to market. My favorite section of the wet market was always the seafood area where I would tug at my mom’s arm to see the Alimango (giant mud crabs), assortment of fishes from that morning, and live tilapia for sale in tanks much too small for them. This was to be my path, but my trajectory changed when an abnormally strong typhoon hit my village. In the aftermath of the storm, streets were flooded and filled with garbage and debris. After living through a week of gales and monsoons and seeing the wreckage of my small fishing village, I knew that I needed to do something to help communities like mine. Ironically, this meant leaving my village and pursuing a new life and educational opportunities in the United States.

Although my interest in marine biology began in the wet market, my path towards a career in marine biology long before the courses and lab experiences I gained in college. It began when I challenged the cultural pressure for immigrant Filipino children to pursue careers in healthcare to earn money to support ourselves, our family, and relatives back home who lack the opportunities. This cultural expectation is deeply rooted in a core value in the Filipino identity called Kapwa: an interconnectedness between people and their environment. This pillar in Filipino culture calls for us to be of service to our communities. Growing up in a multigenerational household, I would often ask my Lola, Lolo, Titas, and Titos (grandparents, aunts, and uncles) about stories of fishing off the reef, playing in aquamarine waters, and wriggling their toes to find Alimango buried in the mud underneath the mangroves, wistful memories for my elders who still remember a way of life that no longer exists. As I progress through my career as a marine scientist, the prospect that a career in being an educator to carry on these stories and scientist to heal the ecosystems that my family and ancestors relied on can serve as an avenue both to pursue my passions and honor my Kapwa becomes increasingly real. My science can make a difference for me, my family, my community and communities like mine throughout the world.

The mission and values of the Science Corps strongly align with my goals of strengthening the relationship and ocean literacy amongst Filipino youth and their ocean. Participating as a fellow for the Science Corps will give me the opportunity to pour back into the communities that have poured into me: sharing stories from my elders and amplifying the stories of elders around Jagna, Bohol.

In addition to your studies, please describe any prior experience that may help you as a Science Corps Fellow.

As a trans person of color, a major obstacle for me in higher education was finding mentors that I could see myself in. If asked what I thought a scientist looked like ten years ago, I would say Bill Nye the Science Guy. And, for most in science, Bill is a reflection of them. The underrepresentation of minorities in science is discouraging and at times deterring. As such, I advocate for more inclusion in higher education and science. As an undergraduate, I served as a board member for the Leaders of Achievement in Biological Sciences, the student board for the Biology Undergraduate Scholars Program, to foster and be a voice for the diverse student body at UC Davis. I was elected as Head Tutor for BUSP where I lead biology workshops and organized study halls for students to receive STEM tutoring and mentored other tutors with their teaching skills, improving outcomes for students marginalized in STEM. Continuing my goal of accessibility to higher education, I returned as a mentor for UCLA's The Diversity Project to mentor the new cohort of students and assist the instructors. As an alumnus of TDP, I provided support for the students and shared my own experiences in the program and in graduate school.

Growing up in low-income neighborhoods and attending schools that lacked the resources to fund adequate STEM classes, I actively seek for ways that I could offer others exciting science experiences that I wish I had. For example, I produced a Marine Biology module at the UCLA Early Academic Outreach Program Math & Science Academy and recruited volunteers to help lead this activity for K-12 students from underserved public schools around LA county. Our closing activity was a virtual dive tour of a Philippine coral reef and of the local Channel Island kelp forests using smart phones. This experience was tremendously rewarding as afterwards students expressed their excitement learning a beautiful ecosystem exists near and that a career in marine biology is achievable.

As I aim for a career conducting marine ecology in the tropics, engaging the local community, and giving back to the people whose land I am working on is vital. I am fortunate to have had the opportunity to collaborate with linguistics students from the University of French Polynesia. Through this, I learned Tahitian to film a presentation of my research plans which will be used to reach Tahitian-only speakers and be used as a resource for Tahitian and English learners. Inspired by this opportunity and knowing Filipino, I return home to the Philippines via the Foreign Language and Area Studies Fellowship from the Department of Education and a following visit after a Conference held in the Philippines to meet with council members in my home village and discuss potential collaborations in restoring and conserving our coastal ecosystems. I fervently believe that my experiences and ties to the Philippines place me in a unique position that prepares to excel at educating and learning fro

Where do you imagine yourself professionally in the future? Check all that apply.

Scientist in academia

In science education

In science outreach

Please expand on your selection above and describe where you imagine yourself professionally in the near (~2 year) and long-term (~10 year) future.

Pursuing a career in academia, interwoven with my passions in education and outreach, becomes an increasingly clear path that marries my passion in marine science and giving back to my community. I've made steps towards my goals by actively seeking opportunities to contribute to my communities locally through science education and outreach for K-12 students in LA county, and internationally with collaborations with linguistic students from the University of French Polynesia. These experiences have equipped me with the skills necessary to continue giving back to my communities in the Philippines. If I receive a fellowship opportunity for the Science Corps, I would design a curriculum where students could supplement their in-class STEM learning with hands-on science experiences through student-centered research projects that exposes them to their local ecosystems and addresses ocean-related issues in the area.

In the near future, after completing my PhD at UCLA, an aim of mine is to collaborate with the Local Governmental Unit from my home in Bataan to reestablish our mangroves forests. I plan to leverage my access to resources via grants and fellowships such as a Fulbright Fellowship and with NGO's based in the Philippines that I've connect with at the United Nations One Ocean Science Congress. Additionally, I hope to continue building my organization, Filipinos of Aquatic and Marine Science (FoAMS). I started FoAMS as I have only met other Filipinos in the field by chance and I wanted to make a community where we could meet peers and mentors who share the Filipino experience. I believe that we possess a deep heritage, knowledge, and lessons with our oceans, rivers, and lakes that the marine and aquatic sciences can benefit from.

Ten years from now, I see myself in a faculty position at an R1 university leading a tropical marine science research group that centers collaborations with stakeholders in the Philippines. Ideally, I would leverage my access to funding and resources from US institutions to support research efforts in the Philippines. I want to contribute to building research capacity by crafting a program where Filipino students and American students from marginalized groups in science can collaborate on research projects in the Philippines and continue their work in the US. This mutually beneficial effort between Filipino and American students would give Filipino students access to lab

techniques and instruments that may not be readily accessible at Philippine State Universities, and American students with a unique opportunity to participate in collaborative research abroad.

Please upload your CV (.pdf)[J.-Amiel-Flores-CV-02012026.pdf](#)**How did you find out about Science Corps?**

An email list in your institution

Referred by a friend/colleague/supervisor in academia

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